Do ECB decisions move the euro more than a normal day?

Eight Governing Council decisions from October 2025 to September 2026, measured with the ECB's own euro reference rate. Written on Saturday 19 September 2026 with data to Friday 18 September.

DECISIONS STUDIED
8
6 holds, 2 hikes

AVERAGE RATIO
0.64
median 0.44; normal day = 1.0

ABOVE 1.5
1 of 8
12.5%, against 20.6% of all days

10 SEP HIKE
1.04
a normal-sized day

01 Question, data and method

Question. Does EUR/USD move more after an ECB decision than on an ordinary day? **Data.** The ECB euro reference rate for the US dollar, one fixing per business day, 313 fixings from 1 July 2025 to 18 September 2026. Decisions come from the ECB press releases; what markets expected comes from the ECB's account of each meeting.

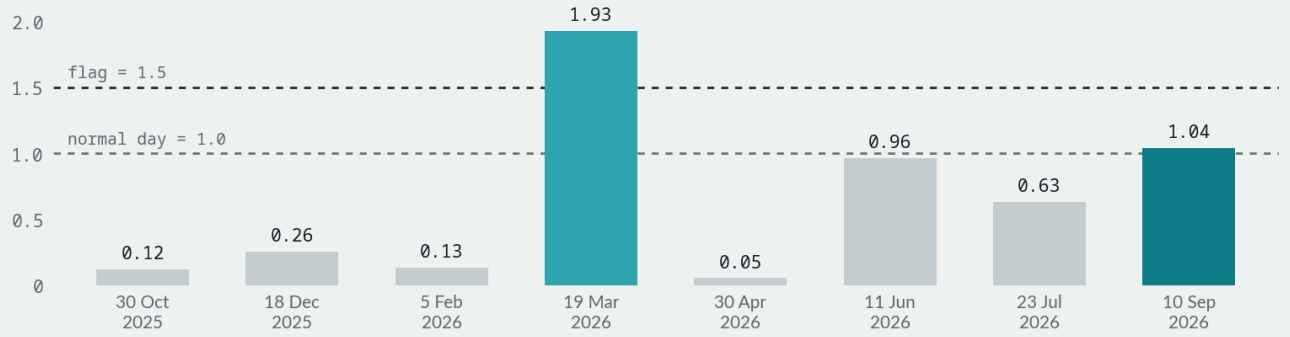
Method. The reference rate is set around 14:15 CET, the same time as the decision, so the decision-day fixing is a pre-reaction level and the next fixing is the first that includes the reaction. For each meeting I take the change from decision day to the next fixing and over the next five fixings. A normal day is the average absolute daily change over the 60 fixings up to decision day. The ratio is the absolute next-day change divided by that normal day; above 1.5 is flagged. As a benchmark, the same ratio is computed for every day in the data with a full 60-day window (252 days).

02 The eight decisions

DECISION	OUTCOME	AS EXPECTED	NEXT DAY	NEXT 5	NORMAL DAY	RATIO
30 Oct 2025	Hold at 2.00%	Yes	+0.03%	-0.15%	0.28%	**0.12**
18 Dec 2025	Hold at 2.00%	Yes	-0.06%	+0.40%	0.23%	**0.26**
5 Feb 2026	Hold at 2.00%	Yes	-0.03%	+0.64%	0.26%	**0.13**
19 Mar 2026	Hold at 2.00%	Yes	+0.57%	+0.44%	0.30%	**1.93** flag
30 Apr 2026	Hold at 2.00%	Partly	-0.02%	+0.50%	0.32%	**0.05**
11 Jun 2026	Hike 25bp to 2.25%	Yes	+0.26%	-0.66%	0.27%	**0.96**
23 Jul 2026	Hold at 2.25%	Yes	-0.13%	+0.74%	0.21%	**0.63**
10 Sep 2026	Hike 25bp to 2.50%	Yes	-0.21%	-1.16%	0.20%	**1.04**

"As expected" compares the decision with market pricing described in the ECB's account of that meeting. Next day and next 5 are EUR/USD changes from the decision-day fixing. Full workings, with formulas, in the Excel file.

03 Result: no clear difference



Next-day move in EUR/USD as a multiple of a normal day. Highlighted: 10 September 2026, and the one flagged day, 19 March 2026.

The euro moved less after the eight decisions than on an ordinary day, not more: 0.16% on average by the next fixing, against a normal day of 0.26%. The average ratio was 0.64 and the median 0.44. One decision day in eight passed the 1.5 flag (12.5%), while 20.6% of all days in the data pass the same test. Eight observations prove nothing, but they give no support to the idea that decision days are unusually volatile.

Seven decisions matched market pricing as the ECB's accounts describe it, and April matched in part (one hike priced by June; the hold called a close call). The two hikes came in near 1.0; the holds in October, December, February and April sit at 0.26 or below.

The one flagged day: 19 March 2026

A hold, with the euro up 0.57% by the next fixing (ratio 1.93). Markets priced the first hike around June, so the hold matched pricing. The data cannot separate the ECB from other news that day, so I do not read the move as a reaction to the decision alone.

This week: 10 September 2026

The hike was almost fully priced in. The euro fell 0.21% by the next fixing (ratio 1.04), a normal-sized day. Over five fixings it fell 1.16%, but that window also holds US CPI on 11 September and other news, so it says little about the ECB alone.

04 Limits

One fixing a day hides intraday moves around 14:15 and the 14:45 press conference, and the next-day window mixes in other news. Eight meetings in one period, most of 2026 shaped by the energy shock, is a small sample. The expectation column relies on ECB accounts published about four weeks after each meeting. The 1.5 flag and the 60-day window are choices; the flag is an input cell in the Excel file, so other thresholds can be tested.

> THREAD: What this week shows about "priced in": when the ECB does what the market already prices, the euro moves about as much as on any other day. The hike was news to nobody, so the euro barely moved.

SOURCES, ACCESSED 21 OCTOBER 2026

1. ECB, euro foreign exchange reference rates, US dollar per euro, series EXR.D.USD.EUR.SP00.A (ECB Data Portal). https://data-api.ecb.europa.eu/service/data/EXR/D.USD.EUR.SP00.A
2. ECB, monetary policy decisions are published at 14:15 CET. https://www.ecb.europa.eu/press/govcdec/mopo/html/index.en.html
3. ECB press releases, monetary policy decisions: 30 Oct 2025, 18 Dec 2025, 5 Feb, 19 Mar, 30 Apr, 11 Jun, 23 Jul and 10 Sep 2026. Individual links in the Excel Sources sheet.
4. ECB accounts of the Oct 2025 to Jul 2026 meetings, published 27 Nov 2025 to 27 Aug 2026 (the July account also gives September pricing). Individual links in the Excel Sources sheet. https://www.ecb.europa.eu/press/accounts/html/index.en.html

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